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VOICE AI PLAYBOOK

RETELL AI × CLAUDE: *your first AI caller* IN 5 MINUTES

Connect Retell's MCP server to Claude Desktop, then build a voice agent and place a real phone call with two prompts. No code, no dashboard clicking.

SETUP TIME	PROMPTS	CODE WRITTEN
~5 min	2	0 lines

BEFORE YOU START

- **Claude Desktop** installed and signed in
- **Node.js** installed (the config runs npx)
- A free **Retell AI** account at retellai.com
- A **phone number** connected to Retell (Twilio via SIP trunk, see step 5)

0:00 MIN

STEP 1 · RETELL

Grab your Retell API key

Log in to the Retell dashboard, open **Settings → API Keys** and copy your key. Keep it private; it can place calls on your account.

1:00
MIN

STEP 2 · CLAUDE DESKTOP

Open the MCP config

Claude → Settings → Developer → Edit Config

This opens `claude_desktop_config.json`. Paste the block below. If the file already has other servers, add only the `"retell"` entry inside your existing `"mcpServers"`.

CLAUDE_DESKTOP_CONFIG.JSON

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "retell": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": [
        "-y",
        "mcp-remote",
        "https://mcp.retellai.com",
        "--header",
        "Authorization:${RETELL_AUTH}"
      ],
      "env": {
        "RETELL_AUTH": "Bearer YOUR_RETELL_API_KEY"
      }
    }
  }
}
```

2:00
MIN

STEP 3 · CONNECT

Add your key and restart Claude

Replace YOUR_RETELL_API_KEY with the key from step 1, save the file, then fully quit Claude Desktop (Cmd+Q / exit from the tray) and reopen it.

> **Check it worked:** open a new chat and look in the tools menu. You should see **retell** listed with its tools.

3:00
MIN

STEP 4 · PROMPT 1 OF 2

Build the call assistant

Paste this into Claude and edit the business details. Claude creates the LLM, voice and agent in Retell for you.

PROMPT 1 · CREATE AGENT

```
Using the Retell tools, create a new voice agent for my business.

Business: [Your business name] - [what you sell / do]
Agent name: Sarah
Goal: Call new leads, introduce the business, qualify them with 3 questions
(budget, timeline, decision maker) and book a 15-minute discovery call.
Tone: Friendly, confident, concise. Keep replies under 2 sentences.
Voice: a natural-sounding English female voice.
If the person is not interested, thank them politely and end the call.

When done, give me the agent ID and a short summary of the setup.
```

4:00
MIN

STEP 5 · REQUIRED FOR REAL CALLS

Connect a phone number via Twilio SIP trunk

Retell needs a number to call from. Bring one from your telecom provider, such as Twilio, using an Elastic SIP Trunk:

1. Buy a number in **Twilio**
2. Create an **Elastic SIP Trunk** and point its origination to Retell's SIP server
3. Add credentials and assign your number to the trunk
4. **Import the number** in Retell and bind it to your new agent

TWILIO SETUP GUIDE ↗

5:00
MIN

STEP 6 · PROMPT 2 OF 2

Make the call

Use numbers in E.164 format (+country code). Test on your own phone first.

PROMPT 2 · PLACE CALL

```
Using Retell, place an outbound phone call with the agent you just created.

From number: +1XXXXXXXXXX  (my Twilio number imported in Retell)
To number:   +1XXXXXXXXXX  (lead's number)
Lead name:   John

After the call ends, fetch the call details and show me the transcript, summary
and call outcome.
```

That's it. Your phone rings and the agent starts talking. Ask Claude to tweak the prompt, voice or questions and call again.

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